



WORLD FAIR, PARIS, 1889

Exciting musical forms and instruments sparked Debussy's imagination when he encountered them at the World Fair in Paris in 1889. The unfamiliar sounds suggested new possibilities to him.

New sounds and influences

The late 1880s were lean years financially for Debussy, but it was also a time of discovery, when he absorbed the diverse influences that came to form his style. Thanks to a wealthy friend, he attended the Bayreuth Festival in 1888 and 1889 and, for a time, came under the spell of Richard Wagner. He was also swept along by the tide of excitement surrounding the World Exposition in Paris in 1889, with the newly erected Eiffel Tower as its centerpiece.

Debussy was especially fascinated by the Javanese gamelan music that he heard, performed on percussive instruments. The